

The dark side for good

Find out how whistle blowers use the darknet for affecting change in society and bringing down surveillance

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Until about a year ago, internet connectivity was just another service to us like Electricity and Cable TV which we'd come to take for granted. None of us ever gave a second thought to whether we would be able to access YouTube as easily we could access Facebook, or access Skype as easily as Whatsapp. But come December 2014, the internet was suddenly abuzz with posts, discussions, videos, interviews, all about one thing: Net neutrality.

In the past five years, the Internet has been globally subjected to a lot of debate pertaining to network neutrality and differential pricing. Countries, as contrasting as Chile and Netherlands, have adopted laws and legislation specifically aimed to keep the Internet an equal platform.

And thanks to the Internet itself, when India's turn came to face its lack of Internet specific laws it wasn't caught unawares.

Specifically initiated by Airtel and subsequently picked up by other network providers, the idea of charging for Over-The-Top services, like Skype or Whatsapp, received renewed vigour since the beginning of this year. Network providers and OTT services have been at loggerheads on this, with network providers demanding a pay-per-use billing model for these services instead of billing based on bandwidth consumed. It is often speculated that the drop in revenues from voice calls vis-à-vis the growth in popularity of VOIP and drop in SMS traffic vis-à-vis chat apps is what prompted telecom operators to push for these measures. On the other hand, OTT services have demanded unregulated access to the internet without any hurdles for their growth and development. In

April 2015, Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (TRAI) proposed a separate Regulatory Framework for OTT services, beyond the standard rules that govern the internet. This violated the basic foundation principle of a neutral internet, or as popularly known, net neutrality. Or did it?

The Unbiased Principle

The principle of net neutrality dictates that data over the internet has to be treated without any bias. This means that the internet can be used for anything by anyone without experiencing additional costs or limitations. For the sake of understanding this concept let's take this example: Consider the internet to be the power supply you receive at your homes. The concept of neutrality dictates that no power supply company or technician is allowed to alter the supply in such a way that you get higher voltage when you use your washing machine than when you use your vacuum cleaner, or charge you extra money if you decide to watch TV.

The terms of watching your TV are decided between you and your cable provider alone, without interference from the power company. Similarly, the terms of an OTT service on the internet should not be under any influence from the underlying Internet provider. This is important for two reasons.

First, Suppose if Airtel provides a Viber only data pack for Rs.100 and a Hike only data pack for Rs.120. To retain its users, Hike will have to find a way to compensate users for that extra 20. And that way might come at the expense of other funds, like R&D and innovation. This reduces their ability to decide their own method of functioning to actually achieve what they set out to do with their idea or product.

Second, one of the basic things that a network provider has the technical power to do is selectively throttling or boosting the access speeds for a certain OTT service. Now, if Flipkart opens at the blink of an eye and Snapdeal keeps you perpetually waiting in a country already at the lower rungs when it comes to average internet speed, we all know which site we will shop from. This hasn't been proposed or tried in India yet, but it might be well on its way once we allow networks to interfere with